

HOUSE No. 3506

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

PRESENTED BY:

Tara T. Hong

To the Honorable Senate and House of Representatives of the Commonwealth of Massachusetts in General Court assembled:

The undersigned legislators and/or citizens respectfully petition for the adoption of the accompanying bill:

An Act relative to digital inclusion for seniors.

PETITION OF:

NAME:	DISTRICT/ADDRESS:	DATE ADDED:
<i>Tara T. Hong</i>	<i>18th Middlesex</i>	<i>1/8/2025</i>
<i>Mike Connolly</i>	<i>26th Middlesex</i>	<i>3/9/2026</i>
<i>Colleen M. Garry</i>	<i>36th Middlesex</i>	<i>3/9/2025</i>
<i>Russell E. Holmes</i>	<i>6th Suffolk</i>	<i>3/18/2025</i>
<i>John J. Marsi</i>	<i>6th Worcester</i>	<i>3/19/2025</i>
<i>Liz Miranda</i>	<i>Second Suffolk</i>	<i>3/18/2025</i>
<i>Samantha Montaño</i>	<i>15th Suffolk</i>	<i>3/5/2025</i>
<i>Francisco E. Paulino</i>	<i>16th Essex</i>	<i>3/11/2025</i>
<i>Kelly W. Pease</i>	<i>4th Hampden</i>	<i>3/17/2025</i>

HOUSE No. 3506

By Representative Hong of Lowell, a petition (accompanied by bill, House, No. 3506) of Tara T. Hong and others for legislation to establish a low-income senior internet subsidy program to provide financial assistance to eligible seniors for internet services. Telecommunications, Utilities and Energy.

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
(2025-2026)

An Act relative to digital inclusion for seniors.

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:

SECTION 1. Chapter 25C of the General Laws is hereby amended by adding the following section:-

Section 10. (a) For the purpose of this section, the following terms shall, unless the context clearly requires otherwise, have the following meanings:

“Low-income seniors”, individuals aged 65 or older whose household income does not exceed 200 per cent of the federal poverty level.

“Senior living facilities”, residential facilities primarily serving seniors, including assisted living communities and nursing homes.

“The office”, the executive office of housing and livable communities.

“The program”, the low-income senior internet subsidy program.

“Wi-Fi hotspot”, wireless internet access points enabling residents to connect to the internet.

(b) The department shall establish and administer the low-income senior internet subsidy program that shall provide financial assistance to eligible seniors for internet services. The department shall: (i) offer monthly subsidies of up to \$50 to offset the cost of home internet services; and (ii) partner with internet service providers to offer discounted plans tailored to low-income seniors.

(c) Subject to appropriation, the office shall allocate grants to senior living facilities for the installation and maintenance of free public Wi-Fi hotspots. Grants shall prioritize funding for: (i) facilities serving communities with limited digital infrastructure; or (ii) high concentrations of low-income residents.

(d) The department shall collect public feedback from senior living facilities and low-income seniors to: (i) better implement the program; (ii) ensure program efficacy; and (iii) address further needs from the community.

(e) The department shall prepare an annual report that includes, but is not limited to: (i) details on the program’s implementation; (ii) the number of seniors served by the program; (iii) the number of facilities supported by the program; (iv) funding requested for the next fiscal year; (v) the overall impact of the program; and (vi) the department’s collected public feedback pursuant to subsection (d). The department shall submit the annual report to the governor, the chairs of the joint committee on telecommunications, utilities and energy, the chairs of the joint committee on elder affairs and the offices of the house and senate clerk.

SECTION 2. This act shall take effect 1 year after its passage.